



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times
MONICA KOSKEY, from left, Peter Kaiser, Steve Hofvendahl, Julio Partida and Jonni Miller all lost homes in the Eaton fire.

Half of burned homes were rentals

Estimated \$30 billion in real estate damage casts doubt on future of affordable housing.

By DOUG SMITH AND SANDHYA KAMBHAMPATI

Real estate losses from the Palisades and Eaton fires could top \$30 billion, and government agencies that receive revenue from taxes stand to lose \$61 million or more annually while homes are being rebuilt, a Times analysis shows.

The analysis, comparing California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection assessments of buildings destroyed and damaged with Los Angeles County assessor parcel records, gives new perspective to the extent of the toll on the two communities. The fires destroyed structures on 56% of all the properties making up the Pacific Palisades. Nearly half of properties in Altadena were destroyed.

More than 300 were commercial buildings. Churches, schools and hospitals were also lost. By far, the biggest impact was on homes.

In all, just under 13,000 households were displaced by the two fires. They came from nearly 9,700 single-family homes and condominiums, almost 700 apartment units, more than 2,000 units of duplexes and bungalow courts and 373 mobile homes that Cal Fire determined were either destroyed or heavily damaged.

About half the single-family properties destroyed in the fires did not have a homeowners exemption, suggesting they were rentals, and their loss could raise questions about the sustainability of the two communities' base of affordable housing.

[See Housing, A7]

The loss of rhythms and routines

‘These connections we all share — that’s what the real stuff is,’ says an Altadena resident whose house is gone

STEVE LOPEZ

They gathered on the street that had been their home until the firestorm blasted through West Altadena, forcing them to flee and destroying all but the memories.

Of the cat that routinely followed a dog around the neighborhood.

Of the kids playing in frontyards and the street before growing up and moving on.

Of the clip-clop sound of horses hoofing by.

Of the actress who wandered the streets, head down, memorizing lines for her next performance.

Of the music from Robert’s homemade instruments, the sizzle from Julio’s backyard grill and the Sunday gatherings at Steve and Lily’s yellow farmhouse.



We measure the losses from the Palisades and Eaton fires in numbers — the thousands of structures destroyed, the billions of dollars in damage and the lives lost. But the casualties include some of the things we often take for granted: the rhythms and routines that fill each day, the comings and goings of neighbors, the histories of the places we call home.

Anthony Ruffin and his wife, Jonni Miller, social workers in the business of housing the homeless, became homeless themselves on Jan. 8. A short time after evacuating their two-bedroom house on West Palm Street, their block was incinerated.

[See Lopez, A12]

Coordinated train heists in the Mojave target Nike sneakers

Total value of items stolen from BNSF is near \$2 million, authorities say.

By ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

The thieves stealthily board eastbound freight trains, hiding out until they reach lonely stretches of the Mojave Desert or high plains far from towns. They slash an air brake hose, causing the mile-long line of railcars to screech to an emergency stop.

Then, they go shopping. That’s the modus operandi described by investigators in a string of at least 10 heists targeting BNSF trains in California and Arizona since last March. All but one resulted in the theft of Nike sneakers, their combined value approaching \$2 million, according to investigators.

New sneaker releases may have touched off at least some of the recent incidents. In Perrin, Ariz., thieves allegedly cut an air brake hose on a BNSF freight train on Jan. 13 and unloaded 1,985 pairs of unreleased Nikes worth more than \$440,000, according to a criminal complaint filed in U.S. District Court in Phoenix. Many were Nigel Sylvester x Air Jordan 4s, which won’t be available to the public until March 14 and are expected to retail at \$225 per pair, the complaint states.

Thief crews typically scout high-value merchandise on rail lines that parallel Interstate 40 by boarding slow-moving trains, such as when they are changing tracks and opening containers, said Keith Lewis, vice president of operations at Verisk’s CargoNet and a deputy with the Mohave County, Ariz., Sheriff’s Department.

Lewis said the thieves are sometimes tipped off to valuable shipments by confederates working at warehouses or trucking companies. Other times they simply look for containers with high-security locks, which they cut with reciprocating saws or bolt cutters, a Homeland Security Investigations special agent said in affidavits filed in federal court.

Once the desired loot is found, the thieves alert “follow vehicles,” which track the train. The stolen goods [See Heists, A11]



Collage by JIM COOKE Los Angeles Times. Photos: Sonoma County Sheriff’s Office; Thomas Young

Vegan group with Bay Area ties linked to deaths in U.S.

Computer savants and activists investigated, charged or deemed persons of interest.

By JESSICA GARRISON AND BRITNY MEJIA

VALLEJO, Calif. — As he prepared to give up the beloved pre-World War II-era ship he lived on in Half Moon Bay and move into a trailer on a lot he owned in this

scrappy city on San Pablo Bay, Curt Lind made a fateful decision.

Lind, then in his late 70s, invited an eccentric group of folks living on a neighboring vintage tugboat to become his tenants.

The neighbors — a group of computer savants and vegan activists committed to the study of human cognition, most of them trans women — moved box trucks on his land. It seemed like a win-win for the free-spirited Lind: They needed a place to

stay, and he had a dream of making a little money by transforming his ramshackle lot into cheap housing for artists, woodworkers and other “makers” who were being squeezed by Bay Area prices.

“We talked a lot, and I thought we were good friends,” Lind said in a 2024 interview with The Times. “They were going to stay at my yard for four months.”

That’s not what happened. The pandemic hit. [See Zizians, A10]

Pope’s condition takes a bad turn

Vatican says Francis had respiratory crisis while being treated for pneumonia and a lung infection. **WORLD, A3**

Newsom asks for \$40 billion

Governor urges Congress to approve additional aid to help L.A. recover from the wildfires. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Businesses bloom in desert

A guide to nine creative spots that help bring a new energy to Twentynine Palms. **WEEKEND, L6**

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 79/52. **B10**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

Printed with soy inks on partially recycled paper.



Get more of the news you need.
Download the app.

